Wait time

Giving everyone time to think

Use wait time to give everyone a chance to retrieve, reason and prepare an answer. Include a pause after a student response before immediately evaluating or asking someone else.

How to do it well

1 Plan a space-worthy prompt. Use a question that needs retrieval, explanation, justification or evaluation; the required pause should match its complexity.

2 Set the expectation. Explain that everyone will think before anyone answers and that jotting may be used when the response has several parts.

3 Wait Time 1: pause after the question. Ask the complete question, then silently count at least three to five seconds—or longer—without rephrasing, filling the silence or signalling a respondent.

4 Sample an answer. Cold call or use the planned response routine so the protected thinking time belongs to the whole class, not only volunteers.

5 Wait Time 2: pause after the response. Let the answer land before evaluating it; give peers time to process, then invite elaboration, a build or a challenge.

What this sounds like

“Everyone think silently about which source is more reliable. I will give you time before asking for an answer. Prepare the reason as well as your choice.”

Classroom example. After asking pupils which source better supports a judgement, the teacher gives silent preparation time before naming a respondent. After the answer, another pause allows the class to consider the evidence. A second pupil then compares the reasoning. The question gives more students access than an immediate request for the quickest raised hand.

Top tips that make the technique work

Match the pause to the question. A complex explanation requires more preparation than a brief factual response; no single number fits every prompt.

Keep the name until after thinking. Naming a pupil first can signal that others need not prepare.

Avoid filling the silence. Rephrasing continuously interrupts the thinking you intended to protect.

Use a jot where useful. A short written commitment gives students a stable starting point for a longer response.

Preserve the second pause. After an answer, allow others to consider it before asking for agreement, challenge or refinement.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Make protected thinking time predictable.	Treating the fastest answer as the best answer.
Keep every student accountable for the prompt.	Announcing thinking time and immediately supplying a hint.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

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